The Consequence Chain

Civic Skill: Long-Term Thinking | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will explore cause and effect over time, building the understanding that small actions ripple forward into consequences — for themselves and for others not yet present.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can explain what might happen next after a choice is made.
- I can extend a consequence chain at least three steps forward.
- I can think about who else might be affected by a consequence, not just the person who made the choice.

MATERIALS

- A large roll of paper or connected cards for consequence chains
- Illustrated starting scenarios: 'If we leave the tap running...', 'If we leave our food scraps in the playground...', 'If we share a game with someone who didn't have anyone to play with...'
- Drawing materials
- Picture book: 'Hey, Little Ant' by Phillip Hoose & Hannah Hoose

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. BOOK OPENER (6 min): Read 'Hey, Little Ant.' Pause before the ending. 'What might happen next? What happens to the ant? What happens to the person who steps? What happens to other ants? What happens to the child who watches?' Demonstrate that one moment branches into many.

2. INTRODUCE THE CHAIN (3 min): Show the starting card: 'If we leave the tap running...' Write it on the first link. 'What happens next?' A child adds the next consequence. Then another. 'And then? And then? And then who else is affected?'

3. GROUP CHAIN (8 min): Small groups each take a different starting scenario. They draw or dictate their chain, trying to reach at least four links. Prompt: 'Is there anyone not in this room who might be affected eventually?'

4. SHARE AND DISPLAY (5 min): Each group shares their chain. Point to moments where the chain involved people not present: 'We thought about people who weren't even here. That's long-term thinking.'

5. CLOSING (3 min): 'Every choice we make is the start of a chain. We don't always see the end. But we can try to imagine it.'

EXTENSIONS

- Environmental consequence chains: connect daily classroom choices to large-scale effects (water, waste, energy)
- Positive chains: 'If we plant trees in the park today, then in 20 years...' — experience hopeful long-term thinking, not just cautionary
- Revisit chains from earlier in the program: 'Remember when we planted seeds? Let's trace the chain from that first day.'

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Can the child extend the chain beyond the immediate and obvious?
- Key language to note: 'eventually,' 'later,' 'when I'm grown up,' 'people who come after us'
- Photograph the chains — they are rich documentation of children's reasoning

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Did children's chains ever reach people outside their immediate experience? What prompted that reach?
- How did children handle uncertainty — 'we don't know what will happen'? How did you hold that productively?

- How does thinking about consequences connect to the empathy work in earlier lessons?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.